

PC discrimination

The 'master/slave' convention used by the computer industry has come under fire from Los Angeles county officials. Officials have asked computer vendors to remove the offensive reference. "Based on the cultural diversity and sen-



sitivity of Los Angeles county, this is not an acceptable identification label," LA County's Division Manager Joe Sandoval said. He added that it's only a request. "I do understand that this term has been an industry standard for years, and this is nothing more than a plea to vendors to see what they can do," he added.

The Director of the Office of Affirmative Action, Dennis Tafoya, said that a search has been launched to identify and replace such offensive labels. Sandoval rejected suggestions that products using the terms 'master' and 'slave' should be banned.

snapshot

Toshiba manufactures world's smallest hard disk that is **22 mm** in diameter and has a capacity of **2 to 3 GB**

Source: Asia Times

The new face of Japan

In what can only be called true e-governance, Japan has appointed a computer-generated lady as its goodwill ambassador to the ASEAN countries. The ambassador has been named Sakura Sanae; Sakura means Cherry Blossoms, and Sanae is an anagram for ASEAN. Instead of creating a stereotyped, stern-faced ambassador, "she is 21 years old, born in 2003 from a PC," says the official statement on the Japanese foreign ministry Web site.

2003 has been designated Japan-ASEAN exchange year. Given the diversity of the ten ASEAN countries, it is difficult to get a goodwill ambassador who understands all the languages, and can cope with the diversity. Japan, to keep up its tech-savvy image,



has created a computer generated ambassador who can visit all ten nations at the same time. Visit www.mofa.go.jp/region/asia-paci/asean/year2003/cg2.html for images of the latest Japanese ambassador.

Itanium2 available as 'Trialware'

"Somebody please buy Itanium", Intel seems to be saying. The company has started a programme named 'Intel Itanium 2 Solution Challenge', under which it offers the Itanium 2 for a trial period of 90 days. Global 500 companies using systems based on Reduced Instruction Set Computing (RISC) can avail of this offer. Intel hopes this will allow the companies to experience its Itanium2 platform, and realise its advantages. "We're bullish on the Itanium2 processor's performance and price advantage versus proprietary offerings," says Lisa

Graff, director of Intel's Itanium Group. Intel claims that out of the top 25 Global 500 companies, 14 have deployed Itanium2 servers under this scheme. The scheme will run until the summer of next year, and Intel is working with vendors and software providers for this program to succeed.

Although the sales of the Itanium are rising, they aren't showing the growth Intel expected from it—Intel, ambitiously, named circa 2003 as the year of the Itanium. The company aimed at selling 100,000 Itanium processors this year, but sales



Spam

Yahoo! v/s Spam

In April 2003, Yahoo! formed an anti-spam alliance with America Online and Microsoft. Now, it's working on DomainKeys—a code that uses public key cryptography to digitally sign the outgoing messages. It will be compatible with two most popular e-mail programs—Sendmail and qmail. According to Yahoo!, most e-mail users are losing trust in e-mail because of spam, and almost half of the messages that it handles are spam. Using sender authentication, Yahoo! expects to regain its credibility, eventually opening paths to more intelligent spam blocking technologies.

Anti anti-spam virus

A virus is using a new trick to launch DDoS attacks against anti-spam Web sites. Called MiMail.L, it spreads through e-mail as a compressed attachment that dodges anti-virus software. It then sends itself to all addresses on the infected computers, and uses these systems to send meaningless traffic to Web sites of anti-spam groups, including Spamhaus, SPEWS and Spamcop that maintain a list of spam-servers, thus helping users to identify spam.

speak otherwise. An IDC report quotes that 4,957 systems based on the Itanium processor were sold in the third quarter of 2003, compared to 10,746 Opteron servers and 24,000 SUN UltraSPARC servers sold.



■ Malaysian pirates begin selling the yet-to-be-released Windows Longhorn for \$1.58 ■ The PSX entertainment system released in Japan but with scaled-down specifications